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Exploring the Representation of Society and Social Change in Six Films of the Spanish Transition (1975-1982)

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Abstract

This paper examines the representation of society in six films released during the Spanish transition to democracy from 1975 to 1982. It does so firstly by examining Spain's historical and political context, then by analysing the depiction of Spanish society in a number of important sequences from these films. The films selected are well-known in Spain, but have not been studied, to date, in depth by Spanish Film studies scholars. They have been divided into pairs to investigate different aspects of their representation of society and its relation to the historical, political and social context. The first two films, *El puente* and *La boda del señor cura* focus on the general situation of Spain during the Transition from two opposing perspectives, as they were made by a communist director and a Francoist one respectively. The second pair of films, *Gary Cooper que estás en los cielos* and *Elisa, vida mía* focus on women and their roles in society. This section analyses the representation of women on film by a female and a male director. The third and final pair of films, *La escopeta nacional* and *Opera prima*, belong to the genre of comedy. The former is a political comedy, which confronts the recent past in an exaggerated way, whereas the latter moves away from politics, which provides no more than a backdrop for the film.

Preface

The transition from dictatorship to democracy that Spain underwent after Franco's death is arguably one of the most important periods of Spain's recent history[1]. This dissertation examines the history of this period from the perspective of film. It has been argued, by scholars including the cinema critic and historian Pierre Sorlin, that film may be used as historical evidence to explore society, its attitudes, anxieties and expectations (Sorlin, 15-16). This paper will use the tools provided by film studies and film analysis as well as those of the discipline of history to examine the period of the transition to democracy and its society in an interdisciplinary way[2].

The dissertation is divided into three different sections, which contain two films each. The first section examines the historical background to Spain's political and cultural situation during the early years of the Transition and analyses the two films *El puente* and *La boda del señor cura*. The second section focuses on the situation of women in society during the Transition, and the changes experienced before and after Franco's death. Although the situation of the woman improved after the end of the dictatorship, women remained, naturally, part of a patriarchal society. The two films *Gary Cooper que estás en los cielos* and *Elisa, vida mía* deal with the situation of women an in society with different

[1] For a detailed account of the history of the Transition and its impact on contemporary society see Tusell (2007).

[2] The two modules *Battle for Memory in Contemporary Spanish Novels*, and *Spanish Film from the 1990s: New Ways of Seeing* inspired me to study the Transition from the perspective of film. The former studied five novels that were written during the transition period and analysed the anxieties of the authors and society. The focused on the importance of film in investigating a period and how useful it can be to use film as historical evidence.

degrees of optimism and both present interesting case studies for examining the representation of women on screen. The third section focuses on the genre of comedy, which is often not given the same importance as other genres (Labanyi and Pavlovíc, 5). Comedies during the transition period acquired different forms that speak to the various social anxieties in relation to the political situation. The two films chosen, *La escopeta nacional* and *Opera prima*, are different in that the former engages in politics, whereas the second one does not explicitly do so. The two films show the different paths taken by comedy during the years of the Transition, and their portrayal of society, as well as the themes they address, provide essential insights into society's anxieties at the time.

Introduction

The death of the dictator Francisco Franco on the twentieth of November 1975 marked the end of the dictatorship and the beginning of a movement towards modernisation, cultural freedom, social change and, most fundamentally, towards democracy. The first democratic elections in 38 years marked the opening up, for non-Franco supporters, of a country in which their political ideas and cultural activities had been repressed. Although the exact dates of the transition period are debated, it is generally considered to have started after Franco's death in 1975 and to have ended in 1982, when the Socialist Party won the second democratic general elections (Pavlovíc et al., 127). The dictatorship had put a stop to the social advances that had taken place during the Second Republic until the beginning of the civil war in 1936 (Caparrós, *El Cine Español*, 22). In the realm of culture, censorship placed similar controls on cultural developments that did not conform to the ideas of what the regime deemed acceptable. The censoring of literature, music, theatre and film, which will be discussed in more detail later, significantly impacted not only the cultural production during the dictatorship, but that of the early transition period. Although the Transition began with Franco's death, the desire for freedom and democracy of those who were not in favour of the regime dated back to the 1960s. Thus, after the dictator's death, social and political issues that had been repressed and/or censored during the regime, such as outlawed political parties and syndicates, and topics considered contrary to the teachings of the Catholic Church to do with sexual freedom, drugs, divorce or abortion began to emerge in discussion: in books, newspapers and in Spanish cinemas (Martínez, 76).

After the abolition of censorship in 1977, as Carlo Lizziani notes, Spanish cinema "sale del fascismo y ha de reconstruirse en el sentido más total del término"[3] (Lizziani in Caparrós, *El Cine Español*, 22). Indeed, after almost forty years, Spanish screenwriters, directors and producers were able to use their work to express previously censored topics. The cinema of the Transition started to become a testimony to the new democratic Spain as well as a reflection of a new kind of Spanish society (Ibid, 386). Moreover, it contributed to the creation of the new Spain by raising questions about the country's politics, culture and society while also helping to reconstruct the collective memory that the dictatorship had erased (Martínez, 76; D'Lugo, *Guide*, 22).

As Agustín Sánchez Vidal has pointed out, a distinction must be made between "the transition of Spanish cinema, the Spanish transition in cinema and the Spanish cinema of the Transition" (Sánchez Vidal, 507). The first refers to the period before the dictator's death, when some filmmakers like Carlos Saura or Victor Erice began to make films critical of the dictatorship during the early 70s. The second refers to the films whose central topic was itself, the Spanish transition to democracy. The third, the Spanish cinema of the Transition, refers to the films made during the years of the democratic transition, and it is the focus of this dissertation. Pedro Almodóvar has come to be regarded as one of the most important directors that emerged during the transition period. However, this dissertation will deliberately not focus on his films as it aims to be a more original piece of writing about less-studied films of the Transition.

This dissertation will focus on six feature films released between 1977 and 1980 to explore what they reveal about the transformations, anxieties, and attitudes of Spanish

[3] "comes out of fascism and has to be reconstructed in the fullest sense of the term", translation mine.

society during the Transition. These films all fall under the category of "reflejo social" or "social reflection" established by historian and film critic Carlos F. Heredero (Ardánaz, 160). The six films selected for this dissertation have received little attention from film scholars but are all essential historical sources from the very initial stages of the democracy. Moreover, they are by directors whose contribution to Spanish cinema has been significant, and who have shaped the development of the film industry (D'Lugo, *Guide,* xii). Here, the aim is to examine the widest possible of number of films that can be analysed in a meaningful way (within the word count) and to highlight their representation of different aspects of the society of the Transition. To explore the reflection of Spanish society on film; to question to extent to which this was political or not; to examine the representation of political and social changes; and, in particular, the representation of democracy. The six films chosen have been studied in pairs that, together, form the three sections of this dissertation. These will not only explore the main themes of the films and provide detailed sequence analyses but will also contextualise the films historically. Thus, each main section will be further subdivided into sections focusing on the historical, political and social context of each pair of films respectively.

The first section will focus on the two films, *El puente* (1977) by Juan Antonio Bardem and *La boda del señor cura* (1979) by Rafael Gil. The second section will look at *Gary Cooper que estás en los cielos* (1980) by Pilar Miró and *Elisa, vida mía* (1977) by Carlos Saura. The third and final pair of films will look at the two comedies *Opera prima* (1980) by Fernando Trueba and *La escopeta nacional* (1978) by Luís García Berlanga .

Methodology

The interdisciplinary approach taken for this dissertation responds to Pierre Sorlin's view that films may be regarded as historical evidence, as they are not produced in a vacuum and are a product of their time (Sorlin, 15-16). In other words, that films can inform us about history and society. While the discipline of history provides information based on the study and analysis of factual information, films, as a cultural product, provide insight into the workings of that society in a way that may be more immediately reflective of its lived reality (Chopra-Gant, 57). Therefore, this dissertation aims to study the representation of society and social change during the Spanish Transition on six films of this period. Thus, the representation of reality in these films will be used as a form of historical evidence to accompany the information provided in historical texts about the transition period (Barber, 61). Moreover, important sequences of the films as well as their themes and characters will be analysed to examine the filmmakers' use of elements such as the mise-en-scène, the dialogue or the editing to portray society. Therefore, the six films, as well as interviews and statements by the filmmakers will provide the primary sources with the secondary literature being divided between the disciplines of history and film studies. The division of each section into three further subsections seeks to further clarify the interdisciplinary nature of this dissertation.

1. The New Spain

1.1 From Dictatorship to Democracy

Two main historiographical trends emphasise different factors as the key elements that brought about the transition to democracy. Historians such as Raymond Carr, Juan Pablo Fusi and Paul Preston among others, belong to the historiographical trend that places specific individuals, such as Adolfo Suárez and King Juan Carlos I, at the centre of the Transition. This trend argues that the Transition was the product of the actions of the political elites in a climate of social complexity and change. On the other hand, another historiographical trend put forward by Carme Molinero, Pere Ysàs or Nicolás Sartorius among others, argues for the crucial importance of social movements, such as the workers' movement, as defining factors for the crisis that the dictatorship suffered during its final years (Araya Gómez, 32-33). Both historiographical trends, however, agree on the plural nature of the factors that enabled the transition to democracy. This section, which will provide a historical contextualisation for *El puente* and *La boda del señor cura,* will firstly examine the importance of the worker's movement during the Transition, and then will provide a chronological account of the key events of the period.

The end of the 1950s and beginning of the 1960s marked a change in the economic and social landscape of Spain (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 17). The Stabilization Plan from 1959, which promoted the inclusion of Spain in the international economy, as well as the regime's aims to modernise the country and open it up to European investment contributed

to the development of the workers' movement (Domènech, 71). The Stabilization Plan led to a reduction in workers' salaries as well as a rise of unemployment as consequences of a higher import of goods from abroad and a decrease in national production (Sánchez Dominguez et al., 30). The beginning of the 1960s was, therefore, marked by an increase in illegal strikes and workers' protests and the development of workers' unions.[4] CCOO, (Comisiones Obreras or Worker Commission), which remained illegal until 1977, became a key component of the workers' conflict during the final decade of the dictatorship (Fishman, 283-284). Moreover, CCOO was a politically independent organisation, which allowed workers who were not politically committed to participate and fight for their rights (Domènech, 76). The workers' movement continued to suffer the repression it had endured throughout the dictatorship, as it presented a challenge to the regime's elimination of social and political dissidence and to the Spanish Labour Organisation (OSE in Spanish), which had been created in 1940 by the regime. The OSE was the sole legal worker's union and all workers were forced to join as a way for the regime to control the working class (Ibid, 73). However, the resistance and strength of the movement were seen during the 1969 State of Emergency, when the regime tried, unsuccessfully, to eradicate the movement by arresting its activists (Ibid, 77-79). The workers' mobilisations continued even after Franco's death and contributed in 1976 to the unfolding of the Transition.

In 1969, Franco had passed a succession law that designated King Juan Carlos I as the king of Spain after the dictator's death. The monarch was chosen by Franco to guarantee the continuity of the regime. Instead, after the short presidential term of Carlos

[4] For an account of the unions that emerged during the 1960s see Fishman (1982).

Arias Navarro, the last president of the dictatorship, King Juan Carlos I appointed Adolfo Suárez as the president on the third of July 1976 (Pavlovíc et al., 127-128). The Law of Political Reform was approved in December of 1976 after a referendum with 77,7% of participation and led to the 1977 general elections as well as the legalisation of the Communist Party (or PCE), which signified Spain's new political pluralism (Ardánaz, 156-157). The democratic general elections that took place on the fifteenth of June 1977 were won by Adolfo Suárez, leader of the centrist coalition Central Democratic Union (or UCD) (Pavlovíc, 128-129). During his presidency, Spain underwent many changes that led to an unprecedented, peaceful transition to democracy. The Amnesty Law of the fifteenth of November 1977 was approved with a parliamentary majority and aimed to facilitate a peaceful transition from the dictatorship to democracy (Ranz Alonso, 309). The Law enabled the release of those who had been imprisoned during the dictatorship for crimes of "political intent", which had been seen as a threat to the regime. Moreover, it also allowed for the return to Spain of those who had been exiled (Ibid, 311). However, the Law also prevented the prosecution of those who had repressed, tortured and executed in the name of the regime and enabled the release of Basque terrorists from ETA (Basque Country and Freedom) (Aguilar, 99). As Davis argues, "Spain chose amnesty as a kind of institutionalised amnesia" (Davis, 863). Indeed, there was a collective and silent "pact" to leave the civil war and the dictatorship in the past. This tendency to bury the past, argues Paloma Aguilar, came from the fear of conflict and the uncertainty of the political situation, that prompted the political elites on both sides to cooperate and argue for the Amnesty Law as the best move forward (Aguilar, 94-96). Another turning point that occurred during the first years of the Transition was the approval of the Spanish Constitution in the referendum of the sixth of December 1978. The Constitution was

approved by political consensus and was voted in favour by the Spanish population. However, the failed coup by lieutenant-colonel Antonio Tejero on the twenty-third of February of 1981, which King Juan Carlos I condemned on television, showed the fragile state of the democracy three years after the approval of the Constitution (Pavlovíc et al., 129). Thus, it is argued by many historians, such as the ones belonging to both historiographical trends mentioned above, that the transition period lasted until 1982 when the Partido Socialist Obrero Español (PSOE) won Spain's second general elections (Araya Gómez, 25-27).

1.2 *El puente* (1977) by Juan Antonio Bardem

In 1955, Juan Antonio Bardem famously published in the manifesto that emerged from the Salamanca Conversations about Spanish cinema, his opinion about the realities of the film industry at the time. He stated that "[t]he problem with Spanish cinema is that it has no problems, that it is not that witness of our time which our time requires of every human creation." (Bardem, 1955). Bardem's intervention in the Salamanca Conversations became iconic of the views of alternative filmmakers of that era. Later, when speaking about his film *Muerte de un ciclista*, he added that "[a filmmaker] [..] must devote his efforts towards a positive, useful cinema that will reveal the reality of things so they will change" (Sadoul, 15). During the Transition, Bardem's ideas took the form of *El puente*, a film that marks the profound sense of social change.

El puente tells the story of Juan, a mechanic working in Madrid who, after being dumped by his girlfriend, decides to ride his motorbike to Torremolinos to spend the long weekend. On his ride to the coast, he crosses paths with individuals who make him conscious of Spain's political and social situation and make him get involved in the workers' movement upon his return to Madrid (Monterde, 53). The protagonist of the film is played by Alfredo Landa, a popular comedian known for the Spanish film genre coined after him of "landismo" that gave rise to lowbrow comedies during the 1970s (Pavlovíc et al., 131). Landa's portrayal of Juan might lead one to assume *El Puente* will be yet another low-brow comedy. However, the tone of the film changes from the beginning of the second act, when Juan decides to take a trip to Torremolinos alone, allowing a portrait of the contemporary situation of Spain gradually to be unveiled to the viewer. *El puente* is, therefore, a political film that capitalises on Landa's stardom and comic credentials to raise social and political awareness in the viewer. Moreover, the profanities, vocabulary and cheap jokes typical of low-brow Spanish comedies, that continuously reappear in the film are vehicles familiar to the Spanish audiences of films associated with "landismo" that Bardem manipulates to transmit his left-wing ideals to a more significant part of the audience (Caparrós, *El Cine Español*, 137).

The following close analysis will highlight sequences that reflect on the urgent social issued of the day. Firstly, it will examine the way the viewer is encouraged to sympathize with Bardem's own political perspective by an appeal to the emotions and creation of an atmosphere of melancholia. Then, it will examine the portrayal of cultural repression and the way that Juan's monologues are used to draw in the viewer. Finally, it will analyse the representation of the workers' movement in and its counterposition to a growing hippie culture.

The first people Juan meets on his trip are the mother and the wife of a political prisoner. Their interaction is the first instant when Juan manifests, if only for a moment, a political conscience (Garrido Caballero, 91). The dialogue in the scene, when the wife tells Juan "a ver si le sacamos entre todos" ("let's see if between all of us we can get him out of here"), clearly appeals to a common effort to fight for the amnesty and release of the political prisoners of the dictatorship. The close-up of the mother's anxious expression, counterposed to Juan's mid-shot with the prison behind him also emphasise the closeness of the issue as well as appeal to the viewer's emotions (Fig. 1 and 2). Another instance in which Bardem appeals to the emotions to manipulate the viewer towards his own political perspective is in the sequence when Juan crosses paths with an Algerian family whose father is looking for a job. The shot reverse shot of Juan and the underprivileged family counterposes Juan, who is eating a sandwich, with the children's faces (Fig. 3, 4 and 5). Moreover, Bardem's slow zoom on both the family and Juan as well as the quietness of the scene create a sense of sadness that makes the viewer sympathise with both the family and Juan when in the next scene he scolds the bar owner for criticising the immigration of North Africans to Spain (Ibid, 90). Thus, Bardem reflects two pressing issues of the Transition, immigration and political prisoners, by appealing to the viewer's emotions through the use of close-ups and silence.

The issue of cultural repression that was, in some cases, still present during the first years of the Transition, is portrayed in *El puente* through Juan's encounter with a theatre company whose van has broken down. After helping them and attending their show, which mocks the Franco regime and pokes fun at Spain, Juan is mistakenly arrested with the company due to the nature of the show. Although he is released shortly afterwards, when it becomes clear that he is not part of the company, he begins to realise,

after speaking to the members of the group, that he may be complicit in the repression still suffered by so many people in Spain. Again, Bardem uses the dialogue in the scene to emphasise the idea that the problems in Spain, specifically regarding cultural repression, are a matter of everyone. This can be seen in the differences between Juan's dialogue, which uses the singular ("mi tiempo" or "my time"; "no es un problema mío" or "it is not my problem") and that of the members of the company, which use the plural ("nos concierne a todos" or "which concerns us all"; "tenemos que buscar la solución" or "we have to find the solution"). After getting back on the road, Juan tells himself not to worry about things that do not concern him, and Bardem uses this kind of monologue to draw the viewer in and make them conscious of Juan's internal dilemma. The declining use of these monologues, therefore, and their lack in the third act also highlight Juan's transformed mentality.

Finally, *El puente* also examines the reality of the worker and the importance of the workers' movement. In one sequence, Juan comes across some old friends when he stops to eat and decides to lie about his economic and social situation. The sequence shows Juan staring at the sandwich he has not been able to eat while his friends, who emigrated to Germany to make more money, keep inviting him to drinks he cannot afford. As he compares himself to his friends, he begins to take account of his personal situation and the situation of the country, which is one of economic instability and social change. Moreover, the working class is also represented in *El puente* juxtaposed to a hippie community, with whom Juan spends a night after getting a flat tyre. One of the hippie women, who embodies the rejection of the system and the nation, tells Juan no woman would like to be touched with dirty and rough hands like (González Manrique, 15). This exchange could be seen to mark a clear distinction between Juan's working class origins

– associated, in this film, with social and political involvement- and the hippie's superficial focus on the body and immediate gratification.

Juan's transformation from willful ignorance towards social consciousness is most clearly depicted at the film's *dénouement*. As Juan rides back to Madrid, the image of him on his motorcycle is interrupted by flashbacks of the crucial moments of his trip that have made him change his point-of-view. Fast-paced editing as well as the close-ups of Juan's face, and the tense, almost thriller-esque, non-diegetic music of the sequence also indicate a change in the tone of the film that mirrors Juan's new perspective. Finally, the change that Juan undergoes during his two-day trip culminates with his decision to participate in the assembly of CCOO alongside his coworkers, something which he had rejected at the beginning of the film. His apathy has now vanished, as he has become conscious of the political and social changes taking place around him in Spain and now wants to become a part of them (Martínez, 83).

1.3. *La boda del señor cura* (1979) by Rafael Gil

Rafael Gil began his career as a filmmaker during the Second Republic and defended the democratic government during the Civil War. However, during the Francoist dictatorship, he began to make films that were increasingly aligned with the regime's ideology (Jordan and Allinson, 13-14). Gil became a prominent director of the dictatorship and, after Franco's death, his films took a turn down the nostalgic path. As Pavlovíc argues, Gil's films reflect the "right-wing political faction's disenchantment, stemming from their inability and unwillingness to accept Spain's new democratic and social

direction" (Pavlovíc et al., 137). Thus, the filmmaker's films of the late 70s provide a different perspective of the transition to democracy. More precisely, they provide the point of view of those who looked at Francoism with nostalgia and at the democracy with pessimism. Moreover, they provide a useful insight into the views and anxieties of a significant part of the population who were still supportive of the regime, and whose existence tends to be overlooked in academic accounts of the films of the Transition.

La boda del señor cura is the film adaptation of the 1977 novel by the same name by Fernando Vizcaíno Casas, who was a writer and lawyer supportive of the dictatorial regime and a friend of Gil's. *La boda* has been selected for close analysis, as it is one of the few right-wing films of this era that functions as a drama rather than as a sarcastic, frivolous representation of the democracy, which was the general tone of such films (Valenzuela Moreno, 429). The film tells the story of father Juan Camí, a Jesuit priest who, after the end of the dictatorship, experiences an ideological change and decides to join the worker's movement and the Communist Party after being arrested for participating in the strike of a group of miners. The film centres around Camí's transformation from a Francoist priest and teacher at a seminary to a communist worker, who decides to break his vow of chastity and leave the Catholic Church. The film then jumps forward more than twenty years to show the evolution of Camí and his former students.

The following analysis of *La boda* will firstly focus on the film's reflection of the loss of Catholic values in society as a consequence of the workers' movement and sexual freedom. It will then examine the film's emphasis placed on the importance of religion, and finally, it will look at its pessimistic view portrayed, both of society and Spain's future via the metaphorical destruction of the regime's values.

La boda del señor cura reflects the waning values of the Catholic Church, family and nation that the Francoist regime promoted and that, for almost 40 years, had been regarded by a significant part of the Spanish population as the pillars of national and individual identity. In the final sequence of the film, which depicts Camí's wedding reception at an old and grimy restaurant, Camí's wife, who is a stripper, decides to strip in front of her wedding guests. In that bluntly metaphorical sequence, as Elizabeth Scarlett argues, the new sexual mores of the democracy are not only revealed but also shamed (Scarlett, 112). Both the low camera angle as well as the close-ups of Camí's face and his students' perplexed faces create a sense of discomfort that contributes to Gil's critique of the new sexual freedom (Fig. 6). Moreover, the scene also alternates flashbacks of the students singing Francoist songs in school twenty-five years ago. The music from the flashbacks juxtaposed to the music to which Camí's wife is stripping not only highlights the changes in society and, specifically, Camí's ideology but also frames these in a negative light, criticising the present and looking back at the past with nostalgia. Furthermore, the transformations of Camí's physical appearance also contribute to the image of someone who has lost his values (Fig. 7 and 8). His clean and shaven appearance at the beginning of the film is countered by his image at the end when his facial hair and careless appearance make him barely recognisable, whilst the former student's, who look at the spectacle shocked, have remained the physically same, as have their moral and ideological values.

The film emphasises the importance of the Catholic Church. In the third act, one of father Camí's former students, although divorced and no longer a regular church-goer, defends the devotion to the Virgin Mary, and the importance of praying to her, to a worker-priest. Thus, this interaction between the priest, who represents the working class, and the

former student, reflects the power that religion and the old values of the dictatorship can have even to help someone who has succumbed, in some ways, to democracy's ideas (Valenzuela Moreno, 433).

Nevertheless, despite the film's emphasis on the positive influence of the Catholic Church, its portrayal of the future does not reflect the same optimism. As the credits roll, these images are accompanied those of excavators outside of the Jesuit school that is about to be demolished to make way for a new skyscraper. This ending carries the symbolic weight of the end of an era signified by the destruction of the religious school and the radical change in character of the former Father (Ibid, 438).

2. Women during the Transition

2.1 The Spanish Transition from Women's Perspective

Including women in the history of the Transition, as well as examining the feminist movement that emerged during the 1960s are crucial to gaining a better understanding of the social and political changes of the transition period (Gallego-Díaz). The majority of the historiography of the period focuses, as mentioned, on the key figures from the political elites and the worker's movement, with the women's movement relegated to the background, if mentioned at all (Toboso, 40). Nevertheless, the feminist movement was a crucial force at the forefront of the fight for democracy during the final years of the dictatorship (Threlfall, 5).

The situation of the woman during the dictatorship was marked by repression and inequality. Francoist doctrine defined women as inferior to men and relegated them to the domestic sphere, where they could exercise the function of mothers and wives (Alonso and Furio Blasco, 8-10). Nevertheless, during the 60s, the feminist movement emerged, and began to fight, in a public way, for the rights of women. Moreover, it contributed to the politicisation of women, who until the emergence of groups, such as the Movimiento Democrático de Mujeres, had tended to remain outside of political life (Threlfall, 13). Additionally, the feminist movement was a collective mobiliser for democracy. Specifically, it worked to promote equality between men and women within the also illegal PCE and CCOO (Ibid, 13-14). Thus, during the transition period, the idea of gender

equality that the feminist movement had been fighting for began to permeate social and political life. From 1976 onwards, critical changes were made to Spanish policy that transformed the situation of women. In 1977, contraceptive methods were legalised, and family planning facilities were created. Furthermore, in 1978, Aticle 32 of the Constitution stated that "el hombre y la mujer tienen derecho a contraer matrimonio con plena igualdad jurídica"[5], which ended with the privileged status of the man over the woman (Campo Urbano and Rodríguez-Brioso, 151). Additionally, 1978 also saw the abolition of the crime of adultery, which, for women, had been punishable with prison. Moreover, also in the family sphere, the policy changes during the Transition, such as the Ley del Divorcio in 1981, or during the democracy, such as the Ley del Aborto in 1985, also contributed to increased freedom and agency for women (Ibid, 150-151). Women's organisations were actively involved in the creation of the former, and the PSOE's support of the legalisation of divorce played a crucial part in defining it as the political option for progress and influencing the party's success in the 1982 elections (Threlfall, 17).

The changes in social and political life during the transition period regarding women also saw the emergence of films that looked at Spanish reality from a female perspective. Moreover, the cinematic landscape also began to include women filmmakers such as Pilar Miró or Josefina Molina (Martin-Márquez, 150). Furthermore, not only female but also male filmmakers such as Carlos Saura or José Juan Bartolomé began to make films about women in the post-Franco society that explored women's identity and roles in society. Thus, the social and political transformations that the Transition brought about were increasingly mirrored on the big screen in their relation to women (Ardánaz,

[5] "Men and women have the right to enter into marriage with full legal equality" translation mine.

169-170). Films such as *Elisa, vida mía* or *Gary Cooper que estás en los cielos* are crucial to understanding the society of the Transition in relation to women's agency and identity, as they reflect society's gender norms and expectations of women (Marsh and Nair, 1-3). Such films also provide an opportunity to analyse how or whether the new political rights that women acquired during the Transition translated into reality in the form of social equality (Jordan and Allinson, 155). Finally, the films analysed in this section also provide an opportunity to examine the representation of women from the perspectives of a female and a male director.

2.1 *Gary Cooper que estás en los cielos* (1980) by Pilar Miró

Despite having graduated from the National Film School (IIEC) during the dictatorship, Pilar Miró directed her first feature film after the Francoist dictatorship. Nevertheless, the filmmaker had already been working as a director in Spanish television since the 1960s. In 1979, Miró directed her most controversial film, *El crimen de Cuenca*, for which she faced a military trial due to the film's depiction of torture by the Civil Guard during the regime. Although the charges against the director were eventually dropped, the case reflected the remnants of the regime's censorship apparatus (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 179). In 1982, the filmmaker was appointed Director-General of Cinema by the then President Felipe González (Martin-Márquez, 177). Her controversial Ley Miró in 1983, sought to increase the cinematographic production of the country by providing pre-production subventions to projects through a selection process (Caparrós, *Historia Del Cine,* 167).

During the controversy over *El crimen de Cuenca*, Miró directed *Gary Cooper que estás en los cielos*, a film of autobiographical nature that reflects the situation of a generation of women in the changing society of the Transition. The film tells the story of Andrea, a television director who, after thinking she is pregnant and going to the gynaecologist, is diagnosed with a potentially terminal tumour that must be operated on immediately. Pilar Miró was diagnosed with a severe heart condition and underwent open-heart surgery several years before she wrote and directed *Gary Cooper*, a film that draws largely from her experiences.

The following analysis of the film will examine the representation of the female body and bodily agency in *Gary Cooper* in relation to Andrea's illness. Furthermore, it will analyse Miró's portrayal of Andrea's emotional crisis and finally, it will explore the contrast between the private and the public space and Andrea's roles in them.

Andrea's struggle for bodily agency is central to the development of her character during the days prior to her operation and is also reflective of the issues facing women during the early years of democracy. Andrea's loss of control over her body occurs in the doctor's office when she is diagnosed with cancer and told she will not be able to have children. During the medical examination, Miró highlights Andrea's helplessness by superimposing the asynchronous dialogue of the next scene over close-ups of parts of Andrea's tense body and pieces of medical equipment (Fig. 9 and 10) (Martin-Márquez, 167). In this way, the information of her diagnosis is revealed to the viewer to the image of an unaware Andrea. As Martin-Márquez argues, "[t]he temporal disjunction situates the film's viewers alongside the doctor in a position of superior knowledge with respect to the as yet unsuspecting Andrea portrayed on screen" (167).

After the diagnosis and in an attempt to come to terms with her situation and regain some sense of control, Andrea stands in front of her mirror and stares at her naked body. This process of self-identification is further emphasised by Miró's close-ups on Andrea's face and body from the point of view of the mirror (Fig. 11 and 12) (Ballesteros, 11). Also as a way to feel in control, after discovering her partner's infidelity, Andrea decides to seduce an old friend who has marital problems. The reasons for this are twofold. On the one hand, it allows her to feel in control of her sexuality and, on the other hand, reassures her that, despite her imminent operation and her inability to have children, she is still desirable. As Ballesteros argues, however, the latter emphasises the patriarchal idea that reduces the value of the woman to her ability to seduce a man (Ibid, 14).

Andrea's emotional crisis due to her diagnosis is framed in the private sphere of the home, which is also associated with the feminine (Ibid, 13). Moreover, Miró's focus on the small actions of Andrea in the private sphere emphasises the protagonist's vulnerable emotional state. A crucial example of this is the sequence that shows Andrea at home during the night previous to the operation. Miró's focus on Andrea's small actions, gestures and facial expressions underline both her lack of bodily agency as well as her anxiety and vulnerability. The former is illustrated by the egg Andrea breaks in the sink and the milk she spills, which Martin-Márquez argues, symbolise the removal of her reproductive organs and her inability to have children respectively (Fig. 13 and 14) (166). Moreover, her vulnerability is emphasised by Miró's shots of Andrea as she nervously wanders around and eventually sits on her desk, cries, and prays to a photograph of Gary Cooper to free her from all evil (Fig. 15).

The private sphere, which is defined by Andrea's moments of self-reflection in her apartment, is contrasted by the fast-paced and predominantly male environment at her

workplace. In *Gary Cooper,* Miró illustrates Andrea's personality in the public space as independent and ambitious. Such qualities, which are associated with the masculine (Ballesteros, 9), are reflected in Andrea's appearance as well as her prioritisation of work over motherhood, which she jokes about saying she schedules her abortions at the end of a production so as to not miss work. Thus, maternity is portrayed as mutually exclusive from her professional career (Gámez Fuentes, 155). Nevertheless, when she is diagnosed, the consequences of her role and sacrifices in the public space become evident. Not only has she lost the opportunity to have children, but the personality she has crafted also prevents her from being able to share her anxiety and pain with others (Ballesteros, 9).

2.3 *Elisa, vida mía* (1977) by Carlos Saura

Carlos Saura began his filmmaking career in 1955, after having graduated from the National Film School (IIEC). His films during the dictatorship are examples of the cultural resistance to the Francoist dictatorship (Stone, 61). Through the use of metaphors and allegories, Saura was able to escape the censors in some instances and produce works critical of the regime, such as *La caza* in 1965, which displays a metaphor of the Civil War and a critique of Francoism (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 200). After Franco's death, however, Saura left behind the films of political nature and turned to more intimate and introspective films that portrayed an analysis of social reality (Caparrós, *El Cine Español,* 161). The prime example of Saura's new thematic is *Elisa, vida mía,* the director's first film after Franco's death.

The film tells the story of Elisa, a young woman who, after years of being estranged from her father, Luís, surprises him on his birthday in his house in the countryside. After the celebration, Luís invites Elisa to stay with him for a few days, and she accepts. Over the next several days, father and daughter spend time sharing stories and reflecting on the past while, privately, Luís writes a memoir from the perspective of his daughter.

The analysis that follows will examine the film's theme of liberation from social constraints in relation to Elisa, Luís and his students at the Catholic school he teaches at. Moreover, it will explore how the intricate narrative structure of the film is used to portray Elisa's journey towards ownership of her own representation.

In *Elisa, vida mía*, Luís embodies the rejection of society's values and expectations. The abandonment of his family years ago and his life in the countryside, isolated from society reflect his rebellion against social constraints (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 52). Moreover, the mise-en-scène of the desolate and vast landscape that surrounds his house highlights his isolation and serves as the ideal site for Elisa's evolution towards her own rejection of society's expectations and patriarchal structure (Fig.16) (D'Lugo, *The Films of Carlos Saura*, 139-141). This is illustrated, for instance, in Elisa's decision to leave her husband, Antonio. Although at the beginning of the film she tells her father that she is not brave enough to leave him, when Antonio visits her by surprise, she decides to end their marriage. The scene takes place in the confined space of Antonio's car, which adds to Elisa's sense of entrapment. However, once she exits the car, leaving Antonio behind, the wide shot of her surrounded by the vast landscape reinforces the idea of her newly gained freedom (Fig. 17 and 18).

Furthermore, the interrogation of the submission of women to society's pre-established roles is illustrated by Luís' take on Calderón de la Barca's *El gran teatro del mundo,* which he is rehearsing with his students. The seventeenth-century play is an allegory that teaches the importance of submitting to the role one has been given in life (Ibid, 146). Nevertheless, as D'Lugo argues, Luís' ironic approach to the play subverts its original meaning and turns it into an interrogation of the submission to preordained social roles (Ibid). Thus, Luís' rehearsal of the play with his students, which Elisa attends, stimulates the interrogation and rejection of the representations and identities that are imposed by society.

The social representation of women is further portrayed in the film through its intricate narrative structure, which alternates the present with representations of the past and of the stories that Elisa and Luís share. Geraldine Chaplin, who portrays Elisa, also portrays Elisa's mother and the anonymous murdered widow from Luís' story. In this way, the different roles Elisa is transposed into emphasise the idea of women's lack of control over their representation and identity. Furthermore, this idea is also illustrated in the collage Elisa makes out of women's photographs in magazines (Fig.19). As D'Lugo argues, the images reflect society's distorted representation of women, which prevents them from creating their own representation and identity (Ibid, 141-142).

Finally, Luís' writing reflects Elisa's evolution toward the control of her own representation. After Luís' health worsens, Elisa volunteers to teach his class, thus inscribing herself in the role of the director and adopting her father's ironic reading of the Calderonian play (Ibid, 147). Upon her return to the house, Elisa finds Luís dead. The final scene of the film, shows Elisa sitting on her father's chair, continuing her father's account of her life. Thus, what has been hinted at in Elisa's direction of the play is now

fully realised: she has assumed her father's role and has become the narrator of her story. As Stone argues, Elisa's continuation of the story "reveals her as the maker of her own future" (72). Therefore, her liberation from society's norms and imposed representations of her culminate with Elisa's construction of her own representation and identity, which is figuratively portrayed by her reading and continuation of her father's account of her life.

3. Comedy: Two Sides of the Same Genre.

3.1 Censorship and its Effects After 1977

Immediately after the end of the civil war, the Francoist regime began to impose the apparatus for censorship that functioned until Franco's death. From 1939, all forms of cultural output were controlled by the regime. Cinema and the press were regarded as particularly influential, as they reached a significant part of society, and were, therefore, more tightly controlled by the censors (Neuschäfer, 50). The regime did not fail to see culture as a site of power and sought to use it to control society (Graham and Labanyi., 5). The ministry in charge of the censorship changed numerous times throughout the years; the Ministry of Interior from 1939 to 1941, the Vicesecretaría de Educación Popular de la Falange from 1942 to 1945, the Ministry of Education from 1946 to 1951 and finally, the Ministry of Education and Tourism from 1951 onwards were in charge of it throughout the dictatorship (Neuschäfer, 48).

The period of the most acute cultural repression lasted until the 1960s and was characterised by the censorship of any texts that did not agree with the ideology of the regime, which centred around the nation, the family and the Catholic Church (Caparrós, *Historia Del Cine*, 278). Moreover, the films that exalted these topics were in many instances funded or supported by the government (Ibid, 280). Furthermore, until the late 60s, there were no specific guidelines that established what could or could not be written or shown, which gave complete freedom to the censors to censor what they deemed

unacceptable (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 9). Regarding film, the cutting of sequences and the changes in the dubbing permeated the cinemas until Franco's death (Ramos Arenas, 243). Nevertheless, from 1963 to 1967 there was a window of leeway regarding films that contained nudity, which led to the famous period in Spanish cine of the "destape". This period started after the appointment of Eduardo García Escudero at the head of the Dirección General de Cinematografía by the then Minister of Education and Tourism, Manuel Fraga (Sánchez Vidal, 507). Escudero's policies promoted a new approach to film subsidies, which changed the category of films of "national interest" to films of "special interest". This did allow for films such as Carlos Saura's *La caza* to be made, but, in general, only led to more nudity on screen (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 18-19). The censorship apparatus continued to work until the dictator's death when censorship quickly disappeared even before it was legally abolished.

After more than 40 years of repression, filmmakers recovered their freedom and took different paths that led them to confront the country's past or to move away from it. The genre of comedy, in particular, experienced both of these tendencies and reflected the different attitudes of the population towards democracy during the transition period (Martínez, 82). As Martínez argues, the end of censorship brought about a "saturation of political topics in film". In this sense, the genre of comedy is particularly interesting to study in relation to the end of censorship, as it developed in two opposing ways. On one hand, some comedies of the Transition added to the "saturation" of politics on film, and on the other hand, some moved away from it, reflecting two very different approaches to the confrontation of the recent past.

As Labanyi and Pavlovíc argue, comedy is usually relegated to a subordinate status because of its appeal to popular audiences (5). Moreover, as Geoff King states, comedy

‘is often taken to be the epitome of light relief or “just entertainment” on film […]’ (King, 2). However, the Spanish comedies of the Transition are valuable indicators of the social changes that occurred during the transition years (Iglesias García, 14). With the newly acquired freedom, filmmakers went on to tackle the subjects that had been prohibited during the regime. However, the films that emerged varied greatly in tone and content. In comedy, two different tendencies emerged; one that confronted the past and the political reality of the present, and one where politics remained the backdrop of the film (Pavlovíc et al., 134).

The comedies that actively dealt with the Transition and Spain’s recent past were divided between those by right-wing directors, such as Mariano Ozores or Rafael Gil, who used the genre of comedy to mock and criticise the democracy and those by left-wing or communist directors, such as Luís García Berlanga or Carles Mira, who ridiculed the Francoist dictatorship (Martínez, 12). On the other hand, the Transition also saw the emergence of the New Madrid Comedy, or simply New Comedy, as well as La Movida. The former counted with directors such as Fernando Colomo or Fernando Trueba, who wanted to break with the Francoist regime and focus on “the progressive but somewhat apolitical middle class and their personal frustrations” (Pavlovíc et al., 134). The latter, whose main exponent is Pedro Almodóvar, also wanted to break with the country’s past and portray an apolitical view of reality. However, the New Comedy was characterised by its restrained and more generic aesthetic depiction of reality as opposed to La Movida’s transgressive and provocative ones (Torreiro, 396-397).

3.2 *Opera prima* (1980) by Fernando Trueba

Fernando Trueba was one of the new filmmakers that emerged during the Transition and was only twenty-four years old when he directed his first feature film *Opera prima*[6], which is considered one of the landmarks of the New Spanish Comedy (Rodríguez Ortega, 3). The filmmaker stated that, with this film, he "[…] didn't want to feature anyone from the previous generation, because Francoism, the sinister, the sadness was boring to me. I needed to breathe" (Gurpegui, 75). As Rodríguez Ortega states, Franco's death and the possible arrival of the democracy had been, during the final years of the dictatorship, "a utopia and an addictive drug" for part of the population (4). Nevertheless, when democracy finally arrived, it brought about a disillusionment among those who had anticipated a different democratic reality and who were disappointed by the consensus between political elites (Rodríguez Ortega, 3). Thus, the gap between the real democracy and the one some had hoped for, created a new generation of apolitical "pasotas"[7], who were no longer concerned with the country's politics and who adopted a cynical view of life.

Opera prima tells the story of Matías, a journalist and aspiring writer in his thirties who, after years of not seeing his younger cousin Violeta, runs into her in Madrid and beings a relationship with her. The film portrays the ups and downs of the couple, caused

[6] The title of the film is a play on words, as it can mean "first work" and "a cousin in Opera", with prima meaning cousin and opera being the district where she lives (Stone, 132).
[7] "pasotas" or "pasotismo" refers, colloquially, to "indifferent" or "indifference"

by their generational differences and respective views of life, but concludes with a happy ending typical of romantic comedies.

The following analysis of the film will focus on the two different views on life represented on the one side by the "pasota" Matías and on the other side by Violeta. Moreover, it will also examine the film's representation of Spain's modernisation during the early years of democracy as well as its closeness to foreign comedies such as Woody Allen's (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 82).

The differences between Matías' and Violeta's world views are established from the beginning of the film. During their first dinner together, the fast-paced dialogue they exchange reveals the pair's different attitudes towards travelling, which Violeta loves and Matías avoids, food, with her being vegetarian and him defending the consumption of meat, and the countryside, which Matías finds dusty and inconvenient. Moreover, their outlook on life is further defined when Violeta asks Matías about the novel he is writing. When he tells her that he is writing about a spy, she does not understand how he can write about something he does not know. While he explains why he does not want to write about real life, as it is too dull and well-known, she quickly returns him to reality by asking him about his separation. This instant showcases how, although Violeta has dreams of travelling and becoming a great violinist, she does not escape reality, whereas Matías uses his novel to do precisely that (Rodríguez Ortega, 4). Furthermore, Trueba's use of the long take and wide shot during the pair's conversation contextualises their relationship and highlights Matías' differences with the apartment's mise-en-scène (Fig. 20). Indeed, Violeta's apartment becomes the main space where the pair's relationship develops and is both a reflection of Matías' desire to find a refuge from reality and Violeta's embodiment of social change. The purple colour of the walls, as well as the incense and bohemian

decoration, make for a mise-en-scène that reflects Violeta's open personality and contrasts with Matías' cynical attitude towards life (Iglesias García, 245-46).

Marsha Kinder argues that, during the 1980s, "Madrid became a spatial trope that facilitated a remapping of the Spanish imagined community" (74). In *Opera prima*, the city does not only provide a setting for the emergence of the new generation of "pasotas" but also showcases the modernising changes of democracy. The first sequence shows a wide shot of Matías exiting the Opera tube station. As he walks away, the shot foregrounds a visa billboard, a sign of Spain's recent modernisation and entry in the international economy (Fig.21) (Rodríguez Ortega, 4). Furthermore, the sequence in which Matías goes to the supermarket towards the end of the film is another example of the modernising changes in Madrid. When Matías pretends to steal products in front of the cameras, he is stopped by the supermarket's security guard. Matías' disproportionate reaction about the surveillance in the supermarket reflects his reservations about the changes in society, not only regarding the increase in surveillance but, more specifically, regarding Violeta and her wishes to travel and see the world.

Finally, *Opera prima* portrays society differently from other Spanish films of the Transition, as it not only avoids the subject of politics but also borrows from the comedies of Woody Allen of the 1970s, thus indicating Spain's new openness to the world (D'Lugo, *Guide*, 82). The film's predominant use of mid-shots and long takes, a consequence of the low budget, convey a natural and realistic look to the film similar to that of the American filmmaker's (Iglesias García, 265). The dialogues too, are characterised by their naturalness and spontaneity, except for some of Matías' interventions, which are more exaggerated and use more elaborate vocabulary, which, again, is reminiscent of Woody Allen films.

3.3 *La escopeta nacional* (1978) by Luís García Berlanga

Luis García Berlanga is considered, along with Saura and Bardem, one of the most successful and original Spanish filmmakers of the twentieth century. During the dictatorship, the filmmaker encountered the regime's censorship apparatus, which prohibited the production of some of his films. After the dictatorship, however, Berlanga made use of the new cultural freedom to make films of political nature that focused on Spanish cultural mores (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 128). *La escopeta nacional* is the first film of a trilogy followed by *Patrimonio nacional* (1980) and *Nacional III* (1982), which were all co-written by Berlanga and the screenwriter Rafael Azcona, well known for his black humour, satirical view of Spain and misogynist attitude (Ibid, 124). As Caparrós argues, *La escopeta nacional* opened the season for Francoism (*El Cine Español,* 160). Indeed, the film takes full advantage of the abolition of censorship and displays a satirical portrayal of new businessmen, corrupt politicians and deviant aristocrats during the dictatorship.

The film, set in 1972, tells the story of Jaume (or Jaime) Canivell, a Catalan businessman who pays to organise a hunt with some of the most influential politicians and high society of Madrid to make business connections to sell his intercoms on a national level. However, from the moment he arrives at the hunt, he becomes involved in an array of slapstick mishaps that eventually lead him to leave the hunt empty-handed (D'Lugo, *Guide,* 55).

The following analysis of *La escopeta nacional* will focus on the film's caricature of the figures of the regime and will examine how the use of sequence shots adds to

Berlanga's criticism of the Francoist regime and the film's pessimistic view of Spain's future.

The most crucial aspect of *La escopeta nacional* is its exaggerated and negative representation of some of the typical figures of the Francoist dictatorship. Their negative attributes are emphasised by the mise-en-scène, which, through the overdecorated and outdated interiors, highlights the characters' social status and mirrors the environment suggestive of the most influential figures of the dictatorship (Fig. 22). In the case of the Marquis, for instance, his obsession with sex is demonstrated through his collection of female pubic hair, which he displays in the living room for everyone to see. Moreover, the costumes also highlight the social status of the characters and their deceiving attributes. This is made clear when Canivell returns to his room after the dinner party. As he removes the tupé he has been wearing since the beginning of the film, it is revealed that he is bald. Aside from the comical factor, the close-up produces a dramatic effect in the revelation of Canivell's baldness to the viewer, who has been deceived from the beginning (Fig. 23).

The negative portrayal of the characters is also emphasised by Berlanga's use of the long takes and sequence shots, which permeate the film and enable two different things. On the one hand, they allow for the action to take place both in the foreground and in the background of the scene, which provides a more complete idea of the characters interactions and their relationships to one another. For example, during the hunt, the sequence shot shows the priest hitting another man whom he believes has stolen some of his partridges. After the two men are separated, and the shot foregrounds Canivell and his secretary, the priest remains in the background and begins another fight. Thus, although the focus of the shot has changed from the priest to Canivell, the priest is still visible in

the background and is further defined as a violent man. On the other hand, the sequence shots also allow for all or almost all the characters to appear in the scene at the same time. Berlanga uses this to put them all on the same level and extend his critique to all of them equally (Vellet).

Moreover, the emphasis on the negative qualities of the characters contributes to the pessimistic tone of the film. The final words that appear right before the credits read "Y ni fueron felices, ni comieron perdices porque allí donde haya ministros un final feliz es imposible".[8] This sentence is both a play on the popular Spanish saying and the partridge hunting party in the film. Indeed, this final sentence summarises Berlanga's critique of the Francoist regime, its influence peddling and the decaying Spanish aristocracy, and foresees a negative future (Martínez, 83).

[8] "And they did not live happily ever after because where there are ministers a happy ending is impossible" translation mine.

Conclusion

The Spanish Transition is characterised by the social and political transformations that the arrival of democracy enabled. The modernisation, cultural freedom and new policies that emerged during this period shaped Spanish society, who had to adapt to Spain's new reality. This dissertation has explored the representation of society and social change in six films released during the Spanish Transition. Furthermore, it has focused on six films that, despite not having been studied in depth by film scholars, provide valuable portrayals of society during that period. To conclude, the following section summarises the key aspects of the six films' representation of the social changes and Spanish society during the Transition.

El puente and *La boda del señor cura* reflect Spain's social changes in the first years of the Transition. Juan and Father Camí, both experience a shift in ideology that is reflected in their respective decisions to join the worker's movement. Nevertheless, the tones of the films and their perspectives on the evolution of the characters are opposed. In the case of Bardem, his communist ideology is reflected in Juan's transformation towards social consciousness, and in the film's emphasis on the importance of the workers' movement. On the other hand, however, Gil's pessimistic portrayal of society reflects a nostalgia for the Francoist regime and its values. Furthermore, the workers' movement is seen as the cause of Father Camí's moral decline. Thus, while both films render the workers' movement as an agent of social change, *El puente* portrays it as the way towards a better Spain and *La boda del señor cura* as the reason for society's moral decline. Finally, the two filmmakers make use of the cultural freedom of democracy in two different ways. While Bardem uses nudity

and profanity to transmit his left-wing ideals to a more significant part of the Spanish audience, Gil uses it to cast shame upon the new sexual norms and freedom of democracy.

Elisa, vida mía and *Gary Cooper que estás en los cielos* reflect the situation of women in a constraining, patriarchal society. Nevertheless, the two films display different accounts of women's ability to regain agency over their bodies and identities. While *Gary Cooper* centres around Andrea's loss of bodily agency and her largely unsuccessful attempts to regain it, *Elisa, vida mía* portrays a more positive view reflected in Elisa's ultimate take of control over her future. Thus, while Miró's portrayal of Andrea and society is mainly pessimistic, Saura's depiction of Elisa's transformation towards ownership of her own identity provides a positive perspective on women's ability to regain agency over their lives. It is also worth noting, that the autobiographical nature of *Gary Cooper* adds to its realism, while Saura's use of a complex narrative structure and intertextuality leave more room for individual interpretations.

Opera prima and *La escopeta nacional* reflect the two trends that emerged during the Transition within the genre of comedy. The former is a testimony to the rapid changes occurring in Madrid during the early democratic years, while the latter displays a satirical portrait of businessmen, corrupt politicians and a decaying aristocracy during the Francoist regime. *Opera prima* portrays a new apolitical generation of "pasotas" in a Spain undergoing fast changes toward modernisation. The film's aesthetic, removed from that of the majority of films of the Transition, as well as its resemblance to foreign comedies such as Woody Allen's, contribute to Trueba's aim of leaving the Francoist regime behind and portraying a part of society in which politics are relegated to the background. On the other hand, Berlanga's film focuses on the dictatorship and displays a caricature of its typical figures. Thus, although *La escopeta nacional* is not a direct representation of the society of the

Transition, it is the product of it. Furthermore, its explicit scenes of sexual character and exaggerated caricature its characters reflect one of the paths taken by the genre of comedy after the abolition of the censorship Laws.

Illustrations

Fig.1

Fig. 2

Fig. 3

Fig. 4

Fig. 5

Fig. 6

Fig. 7

Fig. 8

Fig. 9

Fig. 10

Fig. 11

Fig. 12

Fig. 13

Fig. 14

Fig. 15

Fig. 16

Fig. 17

Fig. 18

Fig. 19

Fig. 20

Fig. 21

Fig. 22

Fig. 23

Filmography

Bardem, Juan Antonio. *El Puente.* 1977.

García Berlanga, Luís. *La Escopeta Nacional.* 1978

Gil, Rafael. *La Boda Del Señor Cura.* 1979.

Miró, Pilar. *Gary Cooper Que Estás En Los Cielos.* 1980.

Saura, Carlos. *Elisa, Vida Mía.* 1977

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